

PRELUDE XV

THE whimsical time-signature $\frac{24}{8}$ indicates nothing more than that all the semiquavers are triplets. This is in no conflict with the C signature; but the *tempo* should be a very lively eight in the bar rather than a mere four. The collisions between the hands (e.g., at the end of bar 2) are least awkward if the semiquaver *arpeggio* figures are in a *leggiere* touch amounting to a finger *staccato* (such as is suitable throughout the finale of the *Kreutzer Sonata*; compare Mendelssohn's Scherzos, *passim*). The disjunct quavers are obviously best in a lively *staccato*; but the more conjunct quavers in bars 4, 5, 9, and 10 should be *legato*, otherwise the ear will scarcely distinguish when the new semiquaver figure of those bars belongs to the left hand instead of the right.

With bar 11 a *cantabile* character sets in with the conjunct pairs of quavers (obviously *legato*), and takes shape in a new melody rising in sequences from the middle of bar 13 to its climax in bar 16, from which the *arpeggio* figure (throughout present in the bass) descends in ten crotchet steps to the end. This descent lends itself to an impulsive *crescendo*, especially when in the penultimate bar the bass rushes upwards against it.

FUGUE XV

THIS Fugue is very rich in its themes. I. The combination of Subject and Countersubject (as in bars 5-8) is maintained at all entries except those in Stretto, though the Countersubject is apt to lose its first bar. Bars 20-30 comprise an exposition (in all three parts) of the Inverted Subject with the Inverted Countersubject. At bar 51 a Stretto is made from the Subject in a form which, by omitting its second bar, heightens its effect and renders the close Answer possible. The same Stretto, led from below instead of above, enters unexpectedly in the middle of bar 60; and at the climax of the Fugue, beginning at bar 77, the Inverted Subject begins to set about the same Stretto, but is capped by the Direct Subject rising away from it in thirds.

II. The Episodes (six in number, besides the final Coda) contain several independent figures. Their foundation is laid, before the entry of the third voice, in bars 9-10, which contain a pair of new figures with their inversions. In Episode 1 (bars 17-19) the semiquaver figure (direct) is combined with two independent contrasted figures forming a Triple Counterpoint (in playing which, as always in Bach, the slowest theme requires the most singing tone—all the more in this case because it is pointedly varied on two of its recurrences). The Triple Counterpoint is put through some of its permutations in Episodes 2, 3, and 5 (bars 31-33, 48-50, and 65-68). In the course of Episode 2 a new descending scale-figure is combined with the inverted semiquaver figure, and this combination is, in its turn, subject to inversions (bars 34-37). Episode 6 (bars 73-76) gathers up this thread with clinching emphasis.

A.B. 99.

The *tempo* is lively, so as to require a little stretching for the unexpected detail in bar 55 (a swell in the second and fourth quavers of this bar will account for it) and a decided relaxation throughout the Coda (bars 82-86).

Prolonged low bass passages (as in bars 31-36) imply full tone.

All tied notes, of course, demand that the tone shall still be singing at the moment of suspension. A breach of *legato* would be particularly unfortunate in this matter in bars 12, 20, and 82. In this last case the immediate repetition of the C is apt not only to break the tie, but to make a false connection of melody with the upper part. (This is why a weaker reading has been foisted on one autograph and adopted in several early copies.) The suspension in bar 58 (very characteristically resolved by the middle of the semiquaver figure) may be kept alive by unobtrusive repetition of the tied note in the middle of bar 57 (an almost automatic procedure on the clavichord).

The shakes in bars 25-26 are either stopped at the last quaver, or else carried through as usual with a turn. The shake in bar 64 ends, without turn, on the sixth quaver. The shake in bar 70 ends, without turn, on either the third or the fourth quaver. The w in bar 22 is meant as a practical substitute for an ordinary shake. If, however, the quavers of the Subject are *staccato*, an ordinary shake is quite possible here; and the sign often means as much; certainly (for example) in bar 78.